moving too rapidly." Brzezinski talked about his trip to China, noting that Beijing's intent to modernize the economy and increase contacts with the West represented a "fundamental change." He also emphasized that its leaders wanted better relations with India.[167]

When Desai returned to India, he told parliament that Vajpayee would travel to Beijing after its session was over to get a sense of Chinese intentions and sincerity.[168] He did find himself having to deny a *New York Times* report that India was prepared to accept and formalize the status quo at the border. He clarified that he had said India would not use force to take back territory.[169] On the back foot domestically on various fronts, Desai also countered criticism that he was making concessions to China, saying India, as the "aggrieved party," would not do so.[170] The government then also faced criticism that it was too slow to lodge a protest against a China-Pakistan highway through Indian-claimed territory in Kashmir. The Chinese vice premier's subsequent endorsement of Pakistan's position on Kashmir when he appeared alongside martial law administrator General Zia ul-Haq did nothing to help the Indian government's case domestically.[171]

There were calls for Vajpayee's visit to China to be canceled. The foreign minister refused, pointing out in parliament that the government was only accelerating the process that its predecessor had started with China and Pakistan. Vajpayee stressed, however, that there was no question that India "will buy peace after surrendering our territory." And it would not allow a repeat of 1962.[172] Subsequently, critics again demanded the cancellation of Vajpayee's visit after problems arose in India's northeast. Desai responded that Beijing would be told to stop supporting insurgents there, but he insisted that a Vajpayee visit was "very essential."[173]

Complications

Moscow was worried about Beijing's overtures to India. As a carrot, it told Delhi that it would now ensure that its maps of the Sino-Indian boundary would correspond with India's claims in the eastern sector at least.[174] But it also made clear its unhappiness that Vajpayee, who was in Tokyo when the Sino-Japanese treaty was signed, did not condemn the agreement for its implied criticism of the Soviet Union.[175]

In the Carter administration, there was a debate about whether or not the Soviet Union was in a stronger position in India than it had been in the past